It was extremely quiet and we called back home frequently to make sure that David and Mary were all right. (They were.) About the only thing I can remember about the vacation otherwise is that we learned to play Scrabble in the course of it, and were hooked. Once we got back we bought a set and played endlessly.

11

When we got back on July 13, I invented my first limerick. A friend suggested a first line, which went "A priest with a prick of obsidian," and dared me to complete it.

After considerable thought, I said:

"A priest with a prick of obsidian Was a foe to the hosts of all Midian. Instead of immersion Within a young virgin 'Twas used as a bookmark in Gideon."

I explained that the "hosts of Midian" was a biblical synonym for evil and that "Gideon" was a reference to the Gideon Bible, but no one thought much of it. However, when I challenged anyone present to do better, no one could.

On that same day, I began work on the book for Henry Schuman. I called it The Chemicals of Life, and even though it was a book intended for teen-agers, I felt it to be a scholarly book, and I did some of the work at school.

12

On July 18, I received a letter from Fred Pohl. He had given up the fight to keep going and was ending his agency. Suddenly I was without an agent again after he had represented me for 4^4 years.

My feelings were mixed. I was sorry that he had failed, but I was eager to represent myself. As he had for most of the time he repre-

sented me, Fred had some money of mine he had held back. Eventually he paid me, but for the final $1,000, I traded him my contracts. He controlled the contracts for my first seven science-fiction books and I would have had to pay him 10 per cent of any further earnings I made on those sales that had taken place while he was my agent. I didn't expect that Fred's cut on what was still to come would amount to $1,000, but it was worth it to me never to have to go through the bookkeeping.

I have never had a literary agent since, and to be honest I have never wanted